Co-Lingo: Research & Interview Summary

What our participants told us, the design decisions it produced, and the peer-reviewed literature behind each decision.

DECO3500 Social & Mobile Computing · Team 5 · Compiled October 2026 · Companion sources: `research/interviews/`, `research/literature/design-decision-literature.md`, `docs/references.md`

1. Method and participants

Two rounds of qualitative interviews exploring how people experience workplace communication when English is not their first language — and how coworkers and supervisors experience supporting them.

Round	Participants	Perspective represented	Main contribution to the design
R1	P1–P6 (6)	P2–P4 are **non-native speakers** describing their own experience (the primary design evidence); P1, P5, P6 are coworkers *supporting* a colleague.	Privacy, embarrassment, "don't single anyone out", speed vs. depth, data not used for performance evaluation.
R2	Jonathan, Kaden, Sharon (3)	Coworkers and a **supervisor**, all native speakers. Their claims about learners are **secondhand**, best paired with R1.	Workplace-specific jargon as the core barrier; trust, accuracy and verification; onboarding for new hires; adoption skepticism.

Ethics / anonymity. Participants are shown here with pseudonyms (P1–P6; first-name pseudonyms in R2). Before this document leaves the team, names must go, no recordings or consent forms may be uploaded publicly, and only consented quotes retained.

2. What participants said

Across both rounds, participants described the **same barrier: unwritten, workplace-specific meaning — not vocabulary**.

P2: "*Usually I understand the English words, but sometimes I don't understand the expression or what the person actually means*" — triggered by a manager saying "*have a crack at it and circle back later*". **Sharon (R2):** "*The main issue isn't that they can't speak English. It's more that workplace communication can be quite specific… 'close this off', 'put this on hold', 'follow up with them'.*" **Jonathan (R2):** a colleague told to put something "*out the back*" went *outside the building*.

2.1 Repeated themes, in participants' words

Theme	Representative quotes
Unwritten meaning, not words	**P2:** "*…still don't understand what the person expects me to do.*" · **P4:** "*everyone laughs at a joke and I understand all the words, but I still don't understand why it is funny.*"
Wants a private, discreet way to ask	**P2:** "*I could quietly check something I didn't understand… then probably not, because then everybody knows I'm the person who didn't understand.*" · **Jonathan (R2):** "*people might be uncomfortable asking the same question five times, but asking a robot would feel less embarrassing.*"
Doesn't want it to single anyone out	**P3:** "*this is the robot for people who can't speak English. I wouldn't like that.*" · **Kaden (R2):** "*I wouldn't want someone to feel like they're being singled out because they speak differently.*"

Explain in layers, keep it fast	**P2:** "*She doesn't just repeat the same sentence. She changes the words and gives examples.*" · **P3:** "*It's too slow. I can't stop, take out my phone, type something, translate it, and then continue working.*"
Learning data must not feed performance review	**P2:** "*I might stop using it… I wouldn't want that information connected to my work performance.*" · **P4:** "*Language support should help people improve, not become part of evaluating their performance.*"
Support, don't replace, human conversation	**Sharon (R2):** "*It should make communication easier, not replace the communication between coworkers.*" · **Kaden (R2):** "*For simple things, I think people should just talk to each other.*"
Trust, accuracy and verification (R2 only)	**Sharon (R2):** "*I wouldn't rely on it for important instructions unless I could verify the information.*" · **Jonathan (R2):** "*…maybe tell you when it's not sure.*"
Help the speaker too, include the group	**P4:** "*…people speaking too quickly or interrupting each other.*" · **Jonathan (R2):** "*if everyone starts talking really quickly or using slang, they might just stop participating.*"

3. Eleven design decisions (DD1–DD11)

Interview findings distilled into the decisions that now drive the prototype. The full annotated decision-by-decision review, with each source's method, context and verification status, is in `research/literature/design-decision-literature.md`.

ID	Design decision	Who said it	Peer-reviewed basis (indicative)
DD1	Explain **what a phrase means and what action it expects** — not word-for-word translation.	P2, P3, P4; Sharon, Jonathan, Kaden	Thomas (1983) *pragmatic failure*; Wray (2002) *formulaic language*; Kankaanranta & Planken (2010) *BELF as business knowledge*; Xiao (2015) *proficiency ≠ pragmatic competence*
DD2	Make clarification **discreet, private, on demand**; avoid voice-activated public interaction.	P2, P4; Jonathan, Sharon	Horwitz et al. (1986) *FL anxiety*; Goffman (1955) & Brown & Levinson (1987) *face*; Edmondson (1999) *psych safety*; Satar & Özdener (2008) *text < voice for anxiety*
DD3	Frame it as a tool **for everyone**, not "the robot for international workers".	P2, P3, P4; Kaden, Jonathan	Goffman (1963) *stigma*; Link & Phelan (2001); Shinohara & Wobbrock (2011) *AT visibility*; Norton (1995) *investment*
DD4	Explain in **layers** (plain definition → rephrase → workplace example), keep the **original wording visible**, add visual cues.	P2, P3; Sharon, Jonathan	Mayer & Moreno (2003) *multimedia learning*; Yoshii & Flaitz (2002) & Yanguas (2009) *text+picture glosses*; Sweller & Cooper (1985) *worked examples*
DD5	Be **fast and glanceable in the moment**, then build an **asynchronous personal glossary / review layer**.	P2, P3, P4; Kaden, Jonathan, Sharon	Kukulska-Hulme & Shield (2008) *MALL*; Wong & Looi (2011) *seamless learning*; Cepeda et al. (2006) *spacing*; Walters & Bozkurt (2009) *vocabulary notebooks*
DD6	Keep **learning/lookup data private** and transparent; keep it **out of performance evaluation**.	P2, P3, P4	Pardo & Siemens (2014) & Slade & Prinsloo (2013) *learning analytics ethics*; Ball (2010) *workplace surveillance*; Draper & Turow (2019) *digital resignation*
DD7	Reduce the **fear of looking incompetent**; use a neutral, non-deficit tone.	P2, P3, P5; Sharon	Edmondson (1999, 2002) *image risk in asking*; Frazier et al. (2017) *meta-analysis*; Krashen (1982) *affective filter* (contested)

DD8	**Augment, don't replace** human conversation; support reciprocal, two-way learning.	P1, P2, P3; Kaden, Sharon	Wenger (1998) *communities of practice*; Roscoe & Chi (2007) *peer-tutor learning*; Traeger et al. (2020) *vulnerable robot → more human-human talk*; Stahl et al. (2014) *CSCL*
DD9	**Support the speaker too**: flag jargon, suggest plain alternatives; help groups **include quieter members**.	P1, P3, P4; Jonathan, Sharon	Giles et al. (1991) *Communication Accommodation Theory*; Rets & Rogaten (2021) *text simplification works*; Sebo et al. (2020) *robot invites quieter members*; Samrose et al. (2021) *meeting-awareness dashboards*
DD10	Signal **confidence/uncertainty**; require **verification**; **escalate to a human** for high-stakes or company-specific meaning.	P2; Jonathan, Kaden, Sharon	Parasuraman & Riley (1997) & Lee & See (2004) *appropriate reliance*; Zhang et al. (2020) *confidence displays*; Agudo et al. (2024) *AI errors in the loop*
DD11	Deliver as a **shared, embodied group agent** (the "robot"), not only a personal app.	Concept framing; Round 2 reactions	Kanero et al. (2018) *robot language learning*; Lee & Lee (2022) *RALL meta-analysis*; Deng et al. (2024) *RALL for adults*; Dautenhahn (2007) *acceptability*

4. Contradictions, tensions and limits

- **Adoption skepticism (Kaden, R2).** Doubts everyone would use it — simple things are quicker to explain in person. The literature agrees technology should *augment*, not replace (Dautenhahn, 2007; Geerts et al., 2021). Report as a live challenge, not a resolved objection.
- **Privacy raised in R1, absent in R2.** Only non-native speakers (P2–P4) raised recording, storage and manager access. Keep the learner voice as the primary evidence for DD6; treat R2's silence on it as a sampling artifact, not evidence it matters less.
- **R2's anxiety claims are secondhand.** Jonathan and Sharon describe why they *believe* colleagues stay quiet; pair with R1's first-person evidence and the FLCAS literature before making DD2 claims.
- **Don't overstate language as the cause of error (Kaden, R2).** His stock-room mistake was "*not necessarily because of their English… everyone makes mistakes at work.*"
- **"Fast" is unmeasured.** Interviews and the MALL literature support immediacy, but no source establishes a latency threshold. Measure it; do not assert it.
- **Robot advantage is unproven.** Lee & Lee (2022) report a medium average effect ($d \approx 0.59$) *against non-RALL comparators*; Kanero et al. (2018) judge robots weaker than human teachers on current evidence. Treat the embodied form factor as a hypothesis to test, not a feature.
- **Population transfer.** Nearly all cited literature comes from classrooms, universities, children, general business or Nordic business settings — not Australian students/graduates. Every design claim above is an inference to validate with our own users, not a finding.
- **No direct workplace trial.** Across all literature consulted, no study tests a private clarification / workplace jargon tool with non-native-speaker *employees*. This gap is itself a contribution worth stating in the write-up.

5. Source integrity note

Bibliographic details were cross-checked, but a number of sources were **paywalled and not read in full** during this pass — these are marked "⚠ Verify" in the accompanying literature review and reference list (e.g. Thomas 1983; Goffman 1955; Edmondson 2002; Stockwell 2010; Pica et al. 1987). Confirm wording against the originals before using direct quotations. One source was identified but deliberately *not* relied on: Bullock & Bisbey (2025, *IJBC*, on workplace jargon). Full APA 7 list: `docs/references.md`.

6. Key references (abridged, APA 7)

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A complete reference list, with full details and verification flags, is maintained in `docs/references.md`.